

Ἐμπεδοκλῆς ὁ Ἀκραγαντίνος

Empedocles of Acragas on Nature and the Four Roots

eul_aid: die

Period: [Κλασική](#) [Classical](#)
Dialect: [Δωρική](#) [Doric](#)
Domain: [Φιλοσοφία](#) [Philosophy](#)
Format: [Ἑμμετρος](#) [Verse](#)
Affiliation: [Presocratic](#)

Empedocles was a Greek philosopher and poet from the city of Acragas in Sicily, active during the fifth century BCE. Ancient sources describe him as a multifaceted figure: a thinker, statesman, and healer. Some accounts suggest he was involved in democratic politics in his city. His life is surrounded by legendary stories, including miraculous deeds and a famous but likely fictional tale that he died by leaping into Mount Etna.

He wrote in verse, composing two major poems. The first, **On Nature**, presents a physical theory of the cosmos. The second, **Purifications**, focuses on religious themes concerning the soul's journey. Only fragments of these works survive, preserved through quotations by later ancient writers. The exact relationship between the two poems is a subject of scholarly debate.

Empedocles is a pivotal pre-Socratic philosopher. His system proposed that all things are composed of four eternal "roots"—earth, air, fire, and water—which are combined and separated by two opposing forces called Love and Strife. This was an influential attempt to explain change in the physical world. His work uniquely bridges early natural philosophy and mystical religious thought. His theory of the four elements became a cornerstone of Western science and medicine for centuries.

Works (3)

- [Ἐπίγραμμα](#) · [Epigram](#) · 1 passages
- [Ἀποσπάσματα](#) · [On Nature and Perception](#) · 164 passages
- [Μαρτυρίαι](#) · [Testimonies](#) · 106 passages

Other Presocratic Authors

- [Ἀλκμαίων ὁ Κροτωνιάτης](#) · [Alcmaeon of Croton](#) · 2 works
- [Ἀναξαγόρας ὁ Κλαζομένιος](#) · [Anaxagoras of Clazomenae](#) · 2 works
- [Ἀναξίμανδρος ὁ Μιλήσιος](#) · [Anaximander of Miletus](#) · 2 works
- [Ἀναξίμενης ὁ Μιλήσιος](#) · [Anaximenes of Miletus](#) · 2 works
- [Ἀναξίμενους τοῦ Μιλησίου Ἐπιστολαί \(Ψευδο-Ἀναξίμενης\)](#) · [Anaximenes-pseudo Miletus Letters](#) · 1 work
- [Ἀρχέλαος ὁ Μιλήσιος ὁ Ἀθηναῖος](#) · [Archelaus of Miletus](#) · 2 works
- [Κλεόβουλος ὁ Λίνδιος](#) · [Cleobulus of Lindos I](#) · 1 work
- [Δημόκριτος ὁ Ἀβδηρίτης](#) · [Democritus of Abdera](#) · 2 works

- [Διογένης ὁ Ἀπολλωνιάτης · Diogenes of Apollonia · 2 works](#)
- [Ἡράκλειτος ὁ Ἐφέσιος · Heraclitus of Ephesus · 2 works](#)
- [Ἡράκλειτος ὁ Ἐφέσιος · Heraclitus of Ephesus II · 1 work](#)
- [Ἑρμόδωρος ὁ Ἐφέσιος · Hermodorus of Ephesus · 2 works](#)